

The Axe EFFECT

Rampant felling of trees in Madhya Pradesh under a dubious Act reveals the Government's callous attitude

| By Ambreesh Mishra |

A green backdrop in the wake of the recent monsoon fails to hide the stumps of fully-grown Sagaun trees that once stood on Kashiram's fields in Dadudhana village of Betul district. The septuagenarian Dalit, along with his son Ramcharan, still awaits payment from a dodgy contractor who logged 200 trees of precious timber on his private land. The contractor carried out his con under the Social Forestry Act 2001, wherein rules have been simplified to enable people to harvest forest wealth standing on their private land. He tricked the artless Dalit victims by getting a chartered forester to prepare a plan, getting approvals from the Forest Department, felling the trees and pocketing profits from the sale. The real owner was only left with false promises of riches. Village after village in Betul, home to Gond and Korku tribals in southern Madhya Pradesh, tell a similar tale. A case in point is 60-year-old tribal Bhabhutya who was paralysed after he was similarly deceived into allowing logging of 150 trees on his land in Gronighat village. His wife Shanta and son Bhimrao still rue the day when they fell for the contractor's slick talk about the windfall awaiting them.

While the controversy over the Panna National Park's tigers meeting the same fate as Sariska's still blazes, the failure to implement Project Tiger in the country's tiger state is not the

only failure of the forest authorities. The Government has also failed to handle major forest-related projects like the Social Forestry Scheme enabled under the 2001 Act.

In June 2008, the Government was forced to issue a blanket suspension of all the applications seeking permission for harvesting timber under the Act. It also constituted a three-member committee, headed by Additional Principal Chief Conservator of Forests M.S. Rana, to look into the complaints of misuse of the Act from districts like Chhatarpur, Balaghat, Chhindwara and Betul. Submitted on December 31, 2008, the report indicted several Indian Forest Services officers of complicity and is gathering dust with the state Government. "It is a sordid sequel of Malik Makbuja of the 1990s," says a serving divisional forest officer (DFO), drawing parallels with the infamous scam in which tribals in Chhattisgarh were similarly cheated.

Rana refuses to discuss his report but the gravity of the situation is only too evident. In July last year, Betul Collector Arun Kumar Bhatt wrote to Azad Singh Dabas, Betul's conservator of forests, expressing his concern over the fact that under the garb of the Act, trees standing on the government land had also been felled. Forest Department documents show that before the Government acted, hundreds of trees had already been felled illegally, with 22 cases reported from 17 villages of Betul district alone.

Social forestry is not the only area where the state has floundered. Joint



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